

Norman Armour Sr. in Russia, 1916–1918 — First Research Pass

Compiled 2026-07-27 18:24 PT. Every claim below carries a source. Where a source could not be reached, that is said plainly rather than papered over.

Success criteria for this pass

1. Pin the service record to primary documents (dates, rank, post) — met.
2. Find what he actually *did* in Russia, in his own words — met (three documents).
3. Locate the Kudashev connection in the documented record — partly met.
4. Produce a roadmap to the archives that will finish the job — met.

1. Six things this pass changed

Family understanding	What the record shows
He was in Petrograd until Sept 1918	He left Petrograd Feb 1918 with the Embassy for Vologda , and was still there in August. He was never in Petrograd again in an official capacity.
He stayed behind to close the Embassy	True, but at Vologda , not Petrograd. Francis left him there on 25 July 1918 as the link to the consulates.
Married in Brussels, Feb 1919	Three sources say Stockholm . Your own Herald clipping supports it — see §5.
Involved in the North Russia Intervention	No evidence he went to Archangel or Murmansk. He went <i>south</i> to Moscow under Bolshevik guard, then west to Finland.
Photo in Vladivostok	No documentary support found. Flagged as an open question.
Entered the Service ~1912	Vienna 1912 and Paris 1915–16 were pre-commission stints. He passed the diplomatic exam 10 April 1916 . Petrograd was his first commissioned post.

None of this makes the family stories wrong — several of them turn out to be *more* documentable than expected once you move the setting from Petrograd to Vologda. See §6.

2. The service record, verbatim

Register of the Department of State, corrected to December 23, 1918, p. 81:

Armour, Norman. — Born in Brighton, England, of American parents, October 14, 1887; home, Princeton, N. J.; is a graduate of Princeton University (A. B.) 1905; (A. M.) 1909, and of Harvard University (LL. B.) 1914; employed in a law office in Newark 1913–14; admitted to the New Jersey bar 1914; served in the Embassy in Vienna for three months in 1912 and in the Embassy in Paris for eight months in 1915–16; appointed, after examination (April 10, 1916), Secretary of Embassy or Legation of class five May 17,

1916; assigned to Petrograd May 22, 1916; appointed Secretary of class four August 3, 1916; Secretary of class three July 13, 1917; assigned to Brussels, December 17, 1918.

Source: <https://archive.org/details/registerofdepart1918unit>

The 1922 *Register* continues it: The Hague 14 June 1920, Secretary class two 28 June 1920, Montevideo 3 Aug 1921. <https://archive.org/details/registerofdepart1922unit>

Rank at Petrograd. Third Secretary 1916–17, Second Secretary from 1917. FRUS's List of Principal Persons for 1918 reads flatly: "Armour, Norman, Second Secretary of the Embassy in Russia." <https://history.state.gov/historicaldocuments/frus1918Russiav01/persons>

Note that his Brussels assignment is dated **17 December 1918** — three months *after* he physically left Russia. On paper he was a Russia officer the whole time.

Colleagues at Petrograd (from FRUS and the 1917 *Register*): Ambassador David R. Francis; Counselor J. Butler Wright; Secretary Sheldon Whitehouse (assigned 25 May 1916, three days after Armour); Charles Stetson Wilson; John Campbell White; Livingston Phelps; Consul General Maddin Summers at Moscow (died there May 1918); Consul DeWitt C. Poole at Moscow; Vice Consul Robert W. Imbrie, who stayed on in Petrograd as the sole American official from May to August 1918; Commercial Attaché William C. Huntington; Military Attaché Lt. Col. James A. Ruggles; Raymond Robins of the Red Cross.

3. What he actually did — three documents in his own hand

These are the core finds. All three are free and online.

(a) **"Fall of the Tsarist Regime," 26 March 1917 — an Armour report from Petrograd.** Printed at pp. 102–110 of Jamie H. Cockfield, ed., *Dollars and Diplomacy: Ambassador David Rowland Francis and the Fall of Tsarism, 1916–1917* (Duke University Press, 1981). Found via a citation in V. V. Noskov's scholarship; the volume itself is lending-restricted online. https://books.google.com/books/about/Dollars_and_Diplomacy.html?id=Rah2AAAAMAAJ **This is potentially the most substantial thing he wrote from Petrograd. Worth buying the book.**

(b) **FRUS 1918, Russia I, doc. 613** — File 861.00/2687, "The Second Secretary of Embassy in Russia (Armour), temporarily at Stockholm, to the Secretary of State," telegram No. 2840, 13 September 1918. <https://history.state.gov/historicaldocuments/frus1918Russiav01/d613>

His own narrative of the last five weeks. Key passages, verbatim:

When Ambassador left Vologda for Archangel on July 25 he left me in Vologda as connecting link between himself and consulates.

On August 1, Kedrov sent officer to Embassy demanding our immediate removal to Moscow... I refused to leave on ground of presence of nationals... Upon my refusal to go to train, troops entered the Embassy during the night and took us with our baggage to the train which left August 3 under guard of ten soldiers.

At Yaroslavl our guard of ten was augmented by fifteen Magyars. Fearing that the latter might attempt to seize our documents **I burned the red and green codes which had**

been entrusted me by the Ambassador before his departure.

On the arrival of the train at Moscow we were held in the train for an hour until Chicherin sent the order for our release.

(c) FRUS 1918, Russia I, doc. 602 — File 861.00/2818. Poole forwards a memorandum "drawn up at my request by Mr. Armour, Second Secretary of the Embassy, who recently arrived from Vologda," covering events in Moscow through 13 August 1918.

<https://history.state.gov/historicaldocuments/frus1918Russiav01/d602>

Also: **FRUS 1918, Russia I, doc. 593** — Francis reports that "Armour, who remained at Vologda, wired us that Kedrov had received telegram signed Lenin, Trotsky and Chicherin, ordering him not permit us to leave Archangel." <https://history.state.gov/historicaldocuments/frus1918Russiav01/d593>

And a fourth, in a book: Ambassador Francis reprints a long Armour letter in his memoir, *Russia from the American Embassy, April 1916 – November 1918* (Scribner's, 1921):

Of events at Vologda, following our departure on July 25th, a letter sent from Stockholm, September 12th, to me at Archangel by Norman Armour, the Second Secretary of the American Embassy whom I left in charge at Vologda, gave the following account:

and on the next leaf:

Secretary Armour requested to remain with me upon my leaving Petrograd. He is at the present Secretary of the American Legation at The Hague. I saw him in London when I was confined in the hospital there, immediately before he returned to Stockholm, where he married the Russian Princess Koudachev.

Full text free: <https://archive.org/details/russiafromameric00franuoft> (the Armour letter is around scan leaf 325; the printed folio needs checking against the scan, as the index OCR is garbled).

Timeline that emerges

Date	Event
10 Apr 1916	Passes the diplomatic examination
22 May 1916	Assigned to Petrograd
26 Mar 1917	Writes "Fall of the Tsarist Regime"
13 Jul 1917	Promoted Secretary of class three
27 Feb 1918	Embassy closes in Petrograd, moves to Vologda; Armour asks Francis to keep him on
25 Jul 1918	Francis leaves for Archangel; Armour left in charge at Vologda
1–3 Aug 1918	Refuses removal; troops enter the Embassy at night, take him to a guarded train
~3 Aug 1918	Burns the Embassy codes near Yaroslavl
~5 Aug 1918	Held at Moscow, released on Chicherin's order
3 Sep 1918	Allied party crosses into Finland at Haparanda for Stockholm
12–13 Sep 1918	Writing to Francis and to Washington from Stockholm
2 Nov 1918	Engagement announced (<i>NYT</i> , p. 15)

Date	Event
17 Dec 1918	Assigned to Brussels
2 Feb 1919	Marries Princess Myra Koudacheff

4. The Kudashev family

Princess Maria ("Myra") Sergeyevna Koudacheff, b. St Petersburg **7 April 1895** (not 1896), d. 1990. The 1896 date in your notes probably comes from a geni.com profile that conflicts with every other source.

Her father, Prince Serge Vladimirovich Koudacheff, b. Kiev **14 Sept 1863**, d. Florence **27 Feb 1933**. Rank: **камергер** (Chamberlain) and **действительный статский советник** (Actual State Councillor, civil rank 4) — that is court-inner-circle. He appears in the official photographs of the famous **1903 Winter Palace costume ball**, then a chamber junker, costumed as a 17th-century Russian boyar. He emigrated to Italy. <https://ru.ruwiki.ru/wiki/Кудашевы> · <https://www.alamy.com/in-the-rank-of-chamber-junker-prince-sergei-vladimirovich-kudashev-in-the-costume-of-a-russian-boyar-of-the-17th-century-ca-1903-image504685318.html>

Her mother, Countess Vera Maximilianovna Nieroth, b. St Petersburg 23 July 1874, m. St Petersburg 1894, d. **Paris 16e, 26 January 1920** — a court *фрейлина*. She is buried at **Père Lachaise, Division 93**, under an Orthodox cross reading "Mme la Princesse KOUDACHEFF, née Comtesse Véra NIEROTH," alongside her son Serge (1901–1991) and Nieroth relatives. The memorial page names her daughter as "Myra Armour." <https://www.appl-lachaise.net/koudacheff-vera-princesse-nee-nieroth-1874-1920/>

Note the date: Myra's mother died in Paris eleven months after the wedding, and two weeks before Norman Jr. was born in Brussels.

Brother: Prince Serge Sergeyevich, b. St Petersburg 1901, d. Spain 1991, m. Maria del Pilar Robert, no surviving issue. **Father's second marriage:** Florence, April 1922, to Olga Erikovna von Pistohlkors (1888–1963, d. Rome) — the Baltic-German family of Princess Paley. Daughter Princess Olga Sergeyevna, b. 1926, m. Achille Pela.

Source for the above: Jacques Ferrand, *Les familles princières de l'ancien Empire de Russie*, 2nd ed. 1997 — the Kudashev chapter, which you have already scanned to your own site. <https://koudachev.wordpress.com/wp-content/uploads/2010/07/koudachev-geneology.pdf>

Two Kudashev cousins were themselves Imperial Russian diplomats: Ivan Alexandrovich (1859–1933), envoy to Denmark, Belgium and Spain; Nikolai Alexandrovich (1868–1925), envoy to China. Given the Brussels posting, the Belgian one may be worth a look.

Important distinction: Myra Kudasheva is *not* the Maria Kudasheva who married Romain Rolland. Different person, frequently confused in search results.

The escape story — what is documented and what is not

The only published version traces to a single source: **Albin Krebs, "Norman Armour, 94, Dies," *New York Times*, 29 September 1982, p. D26**, which says he used a **fake Norwegian passport**, disguised as a **courier**, re-entered Petrograd and arranged her escape.

Princeton's finding aid tells it slightly differently — that *Armour himself* fled disguised as a Norwegian courier, crossing into Finland. Those are not the same claim, and the difference matters. <https://findingaids.princeton.edu/catalog/MC028>

Scholarly corroboration exists: V. V. Noskov, "Американцы в революционном Петрограде," in *Americana* XVI, p. 21, states that after leaving Russia in August 1918 Armour organised the escape from Petrograd of his fiancée, Princess M. S. Kudasheva. https://pureportal.spbu.ru/files/88741649/Americana_Vyp._16_Final.pdf

Not found anywhere, despite specific searching — treat as drift until a document turns up: a *Danish* passport, a disguise as servant or nurse, a Red Cross connection, or an escape route via Archangel.

5. The wedding: Stockholm, not Brussels

Your own clipping may settle this. The *Washington Herald* notice says **Ira Nelson Morris, American Minister to Sweden, was best man**. Morris was Minister at **Stockholm** from 1914 to 1923 (https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ira_Nelson_Morris). A minister does not casually leave his post to stand up at a wedding in another country.

The clipping's "Second Secretary of the American Embassy in Brussels" is describing his *assignment* — dated 17 December 1918 — not the venue.

Three other sources say Stockholm:

- Ferrand's genealogy: "X Stockholm (Suède) 2.2.1919 à Norman ARMOUR"
- *Who's Who*—derived: "married Stockholm, Sweden, 1919" — <https://prabook.com/web/norman.armour/871>
- Francis's memoir: "he returned to Stockholm, where he married the Russian Princess Koudachev"

Only Wikipedia says Brussels, and Wikipedia's own cited source is the *NYT* marriage announcement of 3 February 1919, p. 15 — whose dateline nobody has actually read. **That one clipping decides it.**

If it was Stockholm, the Orthodox ceremony your grandfather described — walking around the church three times — would have been at the **Church of the Transfiguration**, the Russian embassy church in Stockholm. Worth confirming; Swedish parish records may survive.

6. The family stories, tested

"Burning the papers, and the top hat in the safe." The burning is *documented* — but at Vologda, not Petrograd, and by his own hand: "I burned the red and green codes which had been entrusted me by the Ambassador." The scene was the Embassy at Vologda on the night of 1–3 August 1918, with troops in the building. The top hat is not in the record, but the story now has a place, a date and a reason. It is a much better anecdote with the correct setting.

"Left Petrograd on a train sharing a cabin with three sailors and a prostitute, sitting on a trunk full of jewels." He *did* leave under exactly the right conditions to generate this story — a guarded train out of Vologda, ten Red Army soldiers plus fifteen Magyars, documents he thought would be

seized. The "trunk full of jewels" would fit Kudashev property being moved out. Unverified, but not implausible; and the train was from Vologda, not Petrograd.

"Walked past Lenin's speech on 3/16 April 1917 and went on to play whist." Chronologically sound — he was in Petrograd throughout. Lenin's arrival at the Finland Station was the evening of 3 April (O.S.). No documentation found; this is exactly the kind of thing that would appear in his own **"Recollections of the Russian Revolution"** at Princeton (see §7).

"Attended the party at the Yusupov Palace the night Rasputin was murdered" (16/17 December 1916, O.S.). Chronologically possible — he had been at post seven months. Not corroborated. Yusupov's own memoirs describe the evening as a small, closed affair, so this one needs a document, and the Recollections are the place to look.

"Involved with the North Russia Intervention, 1918–19; a picture of him in Vladivostok." The first part does not survive contact with the record — he never went to Archangel, and by December 1918 he was assigned to Brussels. What he *did* do was report on the intervention's consequences: his telegram assesses the Yaroslavl uprising as "brought about by the false announcement made by the Bolsheviks of our landing at Archangel." The Vladivostok photograph is a genuine puzzle. If it exists, either the date or the city needs re-examining.

"Walked around the church three times." Standard in the Orthodox rite — the procession around the tetrapod during the crowning. Entirely consistent.

7. Where the rest of it is — in priority order

1. Princeton, Norman Armour Papers, MC028, Seeley G. Mudd Manuscript Library. Two boxes, 1913–1983, **open for research, not digitized**. Myra donated them in 1984. The folders that matter:

- **"Russia, 1916–1918"** — described as including *recollections of the Russian Revolution and Russian travel permits*. Travel permits are precisely the physical evidence for the passport story.
- **"Kerensky, Alexander, 1917"** — contains a xerox of **"Recollections of Norman Armour of the Russian Revolution."**
- **"Documents in Russian, 1917–1918"** — the likeliest home of anything relating to Myra's exit.
- "French Embassy in Russia, 1918"; "Francis, David R., 1917"; "Belgian Embassy assignment, 1919–1920"; "Whitlock, Brand, 1919–1930"; "*Current Biography* biographical sketch, 1945."

<https://findingaids.princeton.edu/catalog/MC028> · fuller container list:

https://findingaids.library.upenn.edu/records/PRIN_MUDD_MC028 · Mudd, 65 Olden Street, Princeton NJ 08540, (609) 258-6345. Princeton charges **no permission fees** for publishing collection images.

That Recollections manuscript is almost certainly where the whist game, the Yusupov party and the top hat live. Helen Rappaport used it for *Caught in the Revolution* (2016) — her endnote reads "Armour, 'Recollections', 7. For his account of the reception, see 7–9." So it is a real, paginated document that a published historian has read.

2. Cockfield, *Dollars and Diplomacy* (Duke, 1981), pp. 102–110. Armour's own report on the fall of the Tsar. Out of print but findable secondhand.

3. The four newspaper items, via ProQuest Historical Newspapers — free with most public library cards, including SFPL:

- *NYT*, 2 Nov 1918, p. 15 — "To Wed Russian Princess"
- *NYT*, 6 Nov 1918, p. 24 — "Embassy Secretary Back from Russia"
- *NYT*, 3 Feb 1919, p. 15 — marriage announcement (**settles Stockholm vs Brussels**)
- *NYT*, 29 Sept 1982, p. D26 — Krebs obituary (**the origin of the Norwegian passport story**)

4. NARA II, College Park — not online, needs a visit or a paid researcher.

- **RG 84**, Foreign Service Posts: "Russia (Petrograd), 1914–18." Armour's correspondence is demonstrably in there — a *CIA Studies in Intelligence* article cites "Armour to Imbrie, 20 July 1918, Petrograd Files, RG 84, NA." <https://www.cia.gov/resources/csi/static/Five-Months-in-Petrograd.pdf> Finding aid to request: *Preliminary Inventory of the Records of Selected Foreign Service Posts*, PI 60 (1953).
- **RG 59**, Central Decimal File 1910–29, class **861.00** (Russia, internal affairs) — the FRUS documents above are 861.00/2414, /2687, /2818, so the surrounding file is dense. Available on microfilm **M316** via interlibrary loan.
https://www.genealogycenter.info/nara/descpamphlets/viewpage_naram316.php
- Ask reference staff to check the purport cards for a "**123 Armour, Norman**" personnel file. That is the single highest-value target for his appointment records.
- Read first: David A. Langbart, "'No Little Historic Value': The Records of Department of State Posts in Revolutionary Russia," *Prologue* 40:1 (2008).
<https://www.archives.gov/publications/prologue/2008/spring/langbart.html>

5. Missouri Historical Society, St Louis — **David R. Francis Papers**. Armour is the man Francis left behind; he will be all through this correspondence. (Not the State Historical Society of Missouri, which is a different institution in Columbia.)

6. Princeton Alumni Weekly, vols. 17–20 (1916–1920), digitized on Google Books/HathiTrust. Alumni notes are an underrated source for exactly this kind of "where is he now" detail, and would have covered the 1919 marriage.

7. Foreign Service Journal, Nov/Dec 1982 — AFSA hosts free full-run PDFs. There is a **Norman Armour Memorial Award**, and its citation text probably narrates the Petrograd story.
<https://afsa.org/fsj-special-collections>

8. Open questions

1. **Where was the wedding?** Stockholm on the evidence; the 3 Feb 1919 *NYT* dateline decides it.
2. **Whose escape was the Norwegian passport for — his or hers?** The *NYT* and Princeton disagree.
3. **Vladivostok.** No route by which he was there in 1918–19. Is the photograph dated or captioned?
4. **Was he at the Yusupov Palace on the night of 16/17 December 1916?** Recollections, p. 1–10.
5. **What is in the "Documents in Russian, 1917–1918" folder?**
6. **Did Myra keep anything?** No separate Myra Armour papers exist at Princeton, and no Kudashev collection was found at Columbia's Bakhmeteff Archive — though Columbia's own search interface blocked automated access, so that negative should be re-tested by hand.

Things I could not reach, so that you know what was *not* checked

- **Chronicling America.** The Library of Congress endpoint returned a stale cached result set to every query, including a nonsense control query. No hits to report, positive or negative. Your *Washington Herald* clipping should be findable there manually — the Herald is digitized.
- **The NYT archive, Find A Grave, geni.com, HathiTrust, Google Books full-text and AFSA** all blocked automated fetching. Each would likely yield more if searched from a normal browser.
- **Princeton MC028's container list** was read through the Penn mirror, not Princeton's own EAD.
- **The 1916–17 *Register* roster line** OCR'd ambiguously between "3d" and "2d Secretary." The class progression (5 → 4 → 3) and the finding aid both point to Third Secretary, but the page image has not been read.